Expressing dimensions and quantities

Goal: By the end of this lesson, you will be able to give the size of a landmark (height, length, width, area, weight) and to ask about dimensions and quantities: "How high is it? It is 120 metres high."

The idea in two lines: A dimension is expressed with **number + unit + adjective** (*50 metres long*) or **the + noun + of** (*the length of the bridge*). A quantity is asked with **how many** (countable) or **how much** (uncountable).

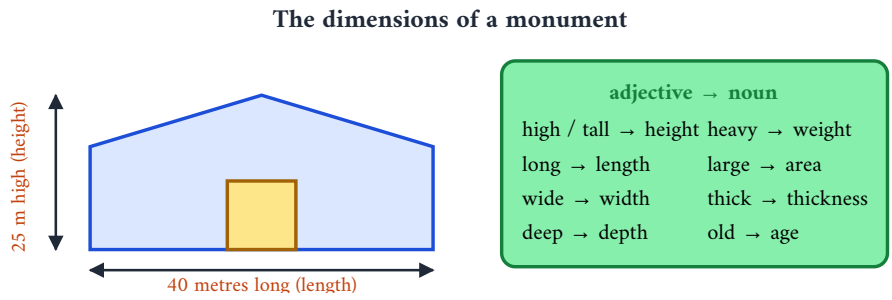


Figure 1: Measuring a monument and the adjective–noun pairs used to express dimensions.

🔵 Rules and concepts

1. **Dimension with an adjective:** *be + number + unit + adjective. The tower is 120 metres high. The wall is 2 metres thick.*
2. **Dimension with a noun:** *The height of the tower is 120 metres.* Learn the pairs: high → height, long → length, wide → width, deep → depth, heavy → weight.
3. **Asking about dimensions:** *How high / long / wide / deep is it? How much does it weigh? What is its height?*
4. **Area and weight:** *It covers an area of 300 square metres (m^2). It weighs 500 tons.*
5. **Countable nouns** (visitors, steps) take *how many, many, a few.* **Uncountable nouns** (water, marble, time) take *how much, much, a little.* Both take *a lot of.*

6. **Big numbers:** *one million visitors; two thousand years old. Million* and *thousand* have no -s after a number.
7. **Approximation:** *about, nearly, almost, more than, over*: *The temple is nearly 2,000 years old.*

🟢 Examples

1. Ask the question for the answer: *It is 90 metres high.* **Answer:** How high is it? **Explanation:** *How + adjective + be + subject.*
2. Rewrite with a noun: *The bridge is 400 metres long.* **Answer:** The length of the bridge is 400 metres. **Explanation:** long → length, followed by *of.*
3. Complete: *… visitors come to the site every year? About two … .* **Answer:** How many visitors … About two million. **Explanation:** "visitors" is countable; *million* stays singular after a number.

🟠 Common BEM mistakes

- Mixing adjective and noun: "the *high* of the tower". Say *the height of the tower* or *it is 120 metres high.*
- Writing "two millions visitors". After a number, *million* and *thousand* take no -s.
- Using *how much* with countable nouns: "How much steps?" instead of *How many steps.*
- Forgetting the unit: "It is 120 high." Always write *120 metres high.*

🟡 Quick review

- is + number + unit + high / long / wide / deep / thick.
- The height / length / width / depth / weight of X is …
- How high is it? How much does it weigh? What is its area?
- How many + countable; how much + uncountable.
- two million, three thousand (no -s after a number).

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